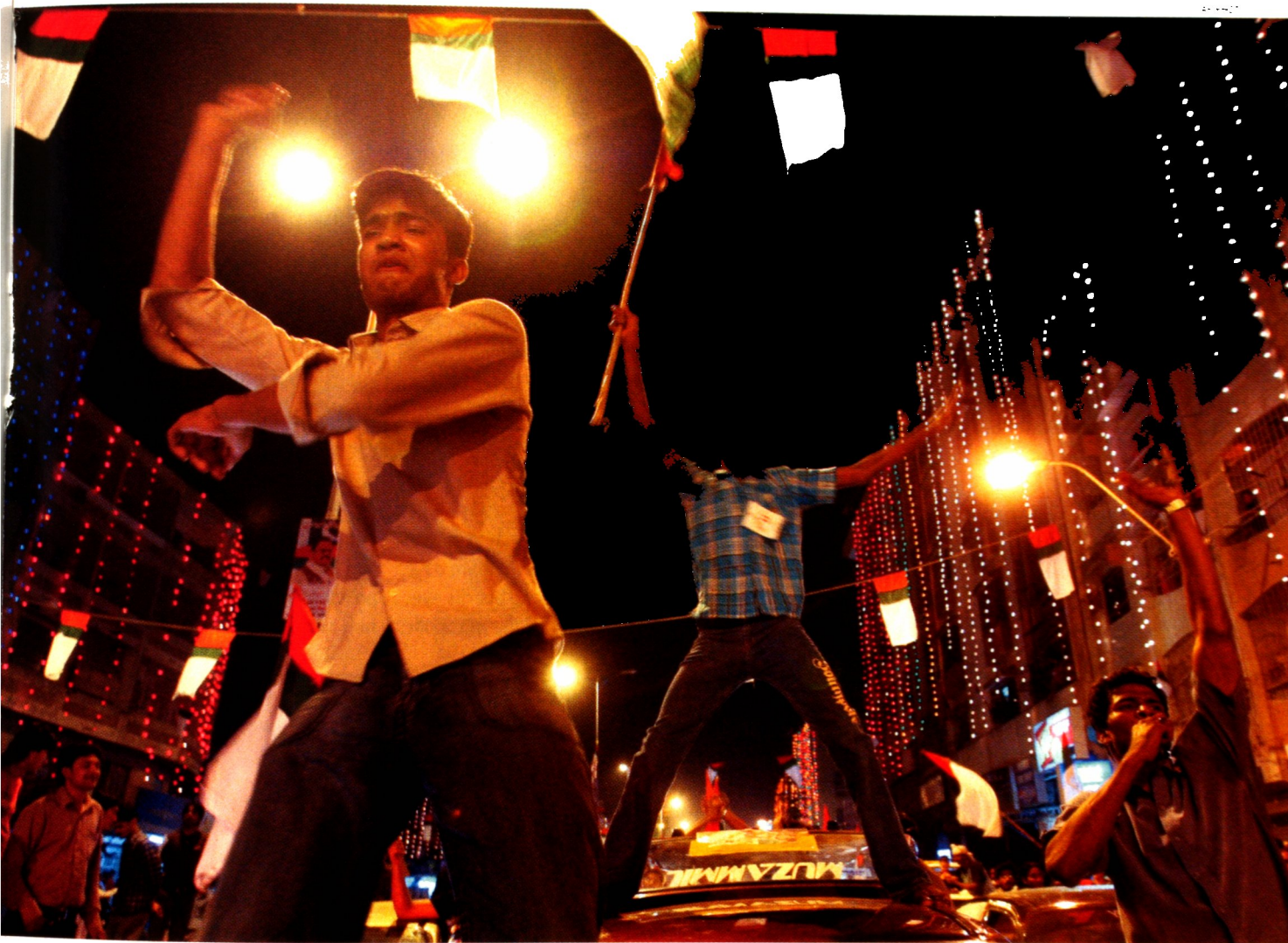




DANCE OF DEMOCRACY: Supporters of the Muttahida Quami Movement party react after the closing of the polls in Karachi on Monday

expectations, Sharif's PML(N) has scored stunning victories in most of Punjab, emerging as the second largest party in the NA with 67 seats. In the provincial Punjab legislature, it has emerged as the single largest party. The biggest story of the day, however, is the rout suffered by the King's party, PML(Q) that has been reduced to a mere 40 seats in the assembly. Almost the entire previous cabinet—some 22 former ministers—and anyone considered close to Musharraf, such as PML(Q) President Chaudhry Shujaat Hussain, have faced humiliating losses. In some places, "strong" PML(Q) candidates, such as former information and railway minister Sheikh Rashid, who had not lost an election since 1985, have come in a distant third, behind PML(N) and PPP candidates.

Equally significant has been the loss suffered by the religious parties' alliance the Muttahida Majlis-e-Amal (MMA) which has seen its share of NA

seats reduced from around 60 to a mere five, and the grouping ceding control of the Frontier and Balochistan provincial assemblies. Although the alliance was expected to do badly after the split in MMA because of the boycott by Jamaat-e-Islami, no one had an inkling of the depth of voter anger. Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Islami leader Maulana Fazlur Rahman, for example, who was also considered close to the establishment, lost one seat he was contesting and barely scraped a win in another.

Most analysts had predicted a fractured Parliament. But what the results show is an overwhelming rejection of pro-Musharraf candidates and a massive victory for the secular Opposition. By all considerations, this is a stinging rebuke for Musharraf and his policies. His political opponents are now in a po-

sition to cobble together even a two-thirds majority in the NA, which although not enough to impeach him, could effectively mean the end of line for him. So, what went against him? A number of factors: obviously anti-incumbency played a major role, especially when coupled with the triple pre-election crises of wheat, gas and electricity. Flour shortages and consequently an almost five-fold rise in its price because of economic mismanagement, led to people having to endure long lines to buy the staple food item from subsidised stores. Massive power and gas cuts grabbed headlines just before the polls. Rising inflation—fuelled by rising international oil prices—provided an incendiary mix. The timing could not have been worse for the candidates touting the support